A very different situation reveals how deeply this mindset was divorced from ground realities. It was November 1962 and Sela and Bomdila had fallen to the advancing Chinese forces. As the then PM sought American help, he tellingly conveyed to the US President that because of its wider implications in the global context, India did not seek more comprehensive assistance. Apparently, we gave precedence to keeping distance from the West than to the defence of the nation! It is this lack of realism that has long dogged our approach to dealing with China. And it is precisely in this domain that we now see the difference.

If the positions and protestations of China got traction with an earlier generation, the state of Indian politics indicates that it is not altogether a vestige of the past. The previous driving factor was a desire to make common cause in the international arena. It was very much propelled by non-Western solidarity and Asian togetherness, more than tinged by ideological proclivity. Since then, public opinion has hardened and the earlier inclination to be excessively trusting is not maintainable. The world, too, is more transactional, and there have been decades of experience that influence thinking in India and China about each other.

How does the contemporary Nehruvian then approach the relationship? In times of stress as we currently are, like Nehru, the inclination is to indulge in ultra-nationalist rhetoric. This is done even while being in denial of the 1962 outcomes, when not actually misportraying it as something more recent. But ideology, habits and connections die hard. So, it is apparently necessary to have a double messaging, one for the more credulous within India and another for a different audience abroad. It is the latter that encourages them to advocate the view that China prizes harmony above all, without questioning why that does not apply to its neighbours. It also leads to admiration of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), while overlooking its violation of India’s sovereignty. There are less-than-subtle suggestions of China’s unstoppability by describing its rise as a force of nature and ill-concealed sympathy for its model of economic growth and technology appropriation.

But it is the actions more than the articulation of these Chindians that are of deeper concern. By consciously underrating the China challenge, any sense of preparation in India was undermined; till the change of 2014. The neglect of the border infrastructure was paralleled by an unwillingness to accelerate industrialization and create deep strengths. Even now, ‘Make in